Asia, was eventually, however, to have repercussions for him. For as Chelmsford pointed out to Montagu in December 1920, ‘When one considers the failure of his [Curzon’s] policy in Persia and Mesopotamia, one is at a loss to understand how he can retain the position of an authority on Eastern affairs.’[192] Wilson summed up his regard for the Foreign Office when he noted in his diary how the newly appointed ambassador to Constantinople, Sir Horace Rumbold, had come to see him; in their half hour talk, Rumbold had learnt more ‘than in all the Foreign Office palavars and papers. That Foreign Office and Curzon are hopeless. They have not even got maps.’[193]

The lacking of maps aside, the most crucial mistake that Curzon made in 1920, however, was to inadvertently encourage a greater affinity between Bolshevik Russia and the Muslim world. In December 1919 the First Lord of the Admiralty, Walter Long had tried to warn of the progress Bolshevism was making in Asia:

The recent Bolshevik successes are likely to give an impetus to what is, it is submitted, one of the most important of Bolshevik aims, namely, to turn the Moslem world against the British Empire... Skilfully making use of every circumstance lending itself to mis-interpretation or distortion, the Bolsheviks have succeeded to make large numbers of Moslems in various parts of the Near and Middle East honestly believe that Great Britain is the enemy of Islam...Very skilfully, too, the Bolsheviks are contriving to turn the somewhat vague and unformed aims of the Pan-Islamic movement, such as it is, into anti-British channels.[194]

Indeed, the ability of the Bolshevik regime to subvert the more extreme points of its doctrine in order to try to appeal to Asian and Muslim malcontents is testament to the pragmatism and opportunism of Lenin and his colleagues. Long’s warning that the danger of a Bolshevik–pan-Islamic combination was not fully realised by some in the British government would indeed appear to be true, given the policy which both Curzon and Lloyd George insisted on pursuing with Turkey. For Curzon in particular,